

OAPA Academy Moodle Platform User Experience Audit

Walaa Ghanduri – UX designer

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1. Introduction

OAPA Academy is an educational program for authors, editors, readers and reviewers to learn and enhance their editing skills. As well as to collaborate with editors in the learning process. It is one component of the architecture of OAPA and the area of focus for the technical development team. The academy utilises Moodle, a Learning Management System (LMS) as the host for their courses. The academy currently runs two courses, 'Foundations of Academic Peer Review' and 'Foundations of Academic Journal Editing'. Both courses are part of the foundation layer, which is a third of the Graduate Certificate at AQF Level 8. The aim of this report is to audit the OAPA Academy Moodle platform from a user experience perspective and to document all inconsistencies and issues that may hinder the user's experience.

1.1 Scope

In this report we will be assessing the course: 'Foundations of Academic Editing', with the assumption that the other courses in the graduate certificate package are following the same structure. The scope of this report is the entire course from the moment it is entered from the Moodle dashboard, all its modules and tabs.

1.2 Objectives

Our objective is to audit the current course UX design against the following criterions:

- The branding according to the official OAPA branding book
- The course structure according to the Programme Architecture, Standard Course Cycle and Functional Requirements of the Development Brief document
- The User Experience Design Heuristics and the laws of UX
- The WCAG principles for accessibility

The evident violations or failure to meet the requirements will be documented in detail. These violations will be utilised in the process of creating new ideas for the platform as well as prototyping and developing with the brand and user experience in mind.

2. Methodology

The UX audit uses a structured evaluation to identify usability issues that the user may be facing. The methodology evaluation was conducted in the following steps:

1. Platform exploration; the Moodle platform was explored from the perspective of a user.
2. Issue identification; identifying that there is an issue
3. Evaluation against principles (from the Objectives)
4. Documentation
5. Severity assessment

3. The Audit Findings

Issue 1: Navigation in main content area

When the user lands in the course, by default they are under the 'Course' tab and the 'Welcome' module. As shown in Figure 1.

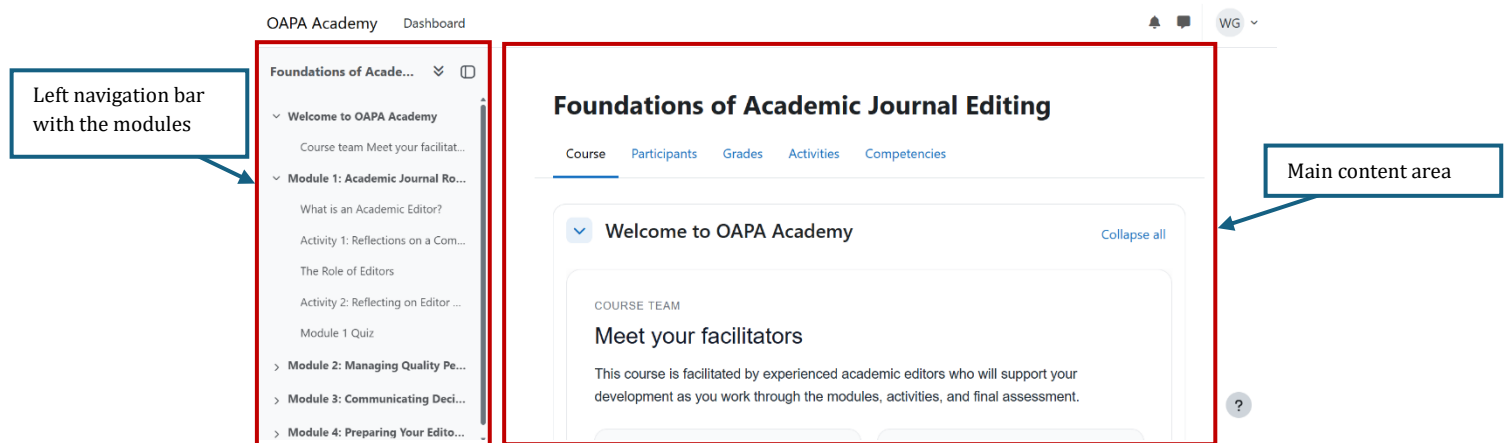


Figure 1: Foundations course landing page

We can see the left navigation bar, typical in learning systems and course providers such as Canvas and Coursera. The main issue here is the main content area also provides the same form of navigation to the left panel, except with more details as shown in Figure 2.

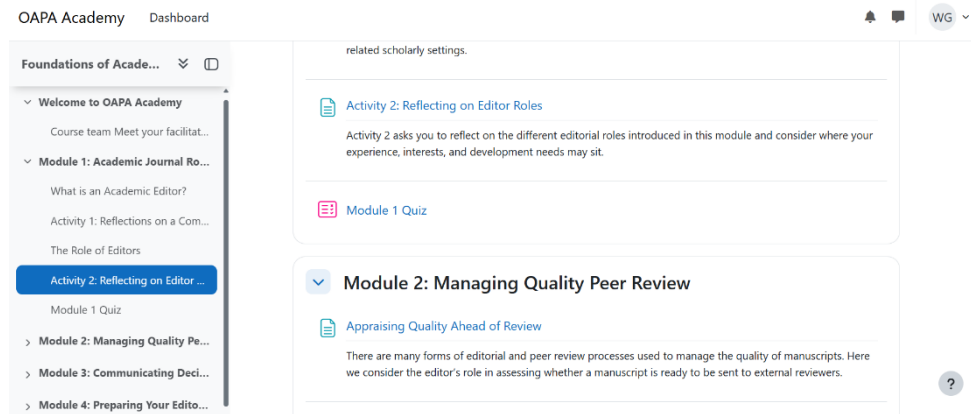


Figure 2: Navigation in the default page

This raises several issues:

1. **Consistency and standards:** the main content navigation appears once, at the beginning of the user session when entered the course. When the user clicks on a module or a link, the navigation never appears again unless they go to the dashboard and click on the course again. This creates an issue with consistency and standards.
2. **Flexibility and efficiency:** the content in the main content navigation and the left navigation tab are the same. This creates redundancy of information.
3. **Cognitive load:** the user will have the same two options when they first enter the course. This will increase their cognitive load and increases the decisions they must make resulting in more focus in navigation than on the course content itself.
4. **Does not support client requirements:** the content needs to be separated per module, although it is asynchronous, there are rules applied to move from one module to another. Having the main content navigation exposing the modules (include module 4) is against the client objectives.

Recommendation: remove the main content navigation to reduce cognitive load on the users and make the navigation for the modules consistent.

Issue 2: Lack of progress indicators

As shown in Figure 1 and 2, the left navigation panel lacks visible progress indicators, raising the following issues/ issues with:

1. **Client requirements mismatch:** the client requires 'Self-paced navigation through each module with visible progress indicators.'
2. **Visibility of system status:** the user does not know how much they have completed and where they are in the course, especially since the content is asynchronous.
3. **Error prevention:** the user might not have completed the required activity to move on to the last assessment or to unlock the next module, it is best to show them their progress than wait for an error message at the end of the module.
4. **Recognition rather than recall:** the users have to keep a mental note on their progress, if they skipped content to read later in the day or week, they would not know which one it is.

Recommendation: add progress indicators to each module and tabs under the modules in the left navigation panel.

Issue 3: Navigation in modules

The modules have a similar form of navigation to issue 1. When clicking on the Module 1 for example, it takes the user to a navigation page in the main content area for all module 1 content except the activity. Although the modules are asynchronous, the navigation is still redundant. As shown in figure 3, the modules' content is shown in the module page. Figure 4 shows the inclusion of the clickable link for 'Activity' and the 'Quiz' even though these ones are not accessible unless the user completes the modules and attends a workshop.

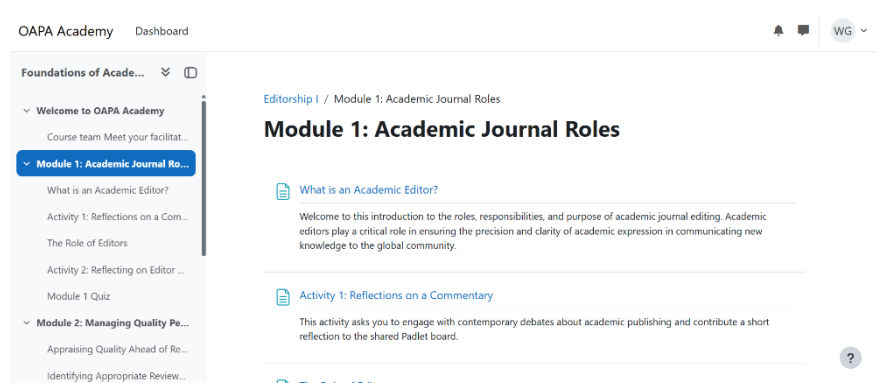


Figure 3: The module navigation

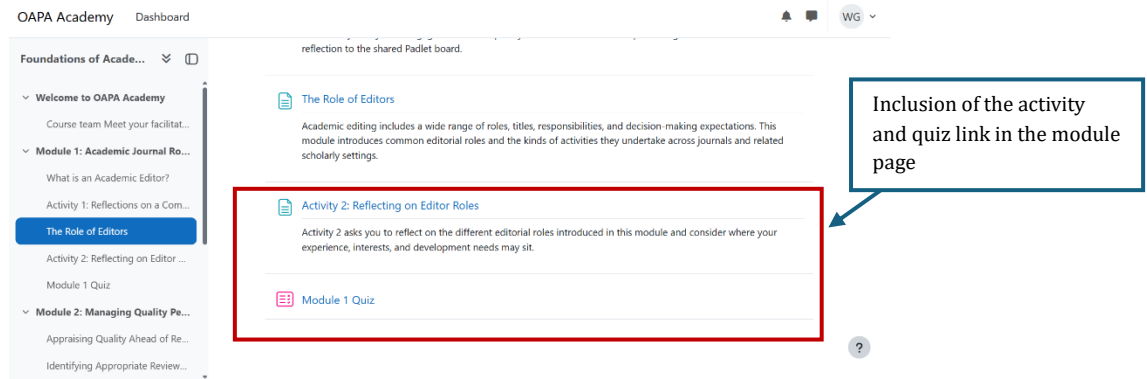


Figure 4: Module 1 navigation

Recommendation: remove the navigation for the module and make the page an introduction of the module, and its objectives. Add buttons to move to the next one or go back but also have the option to use the navigation panel on the left.

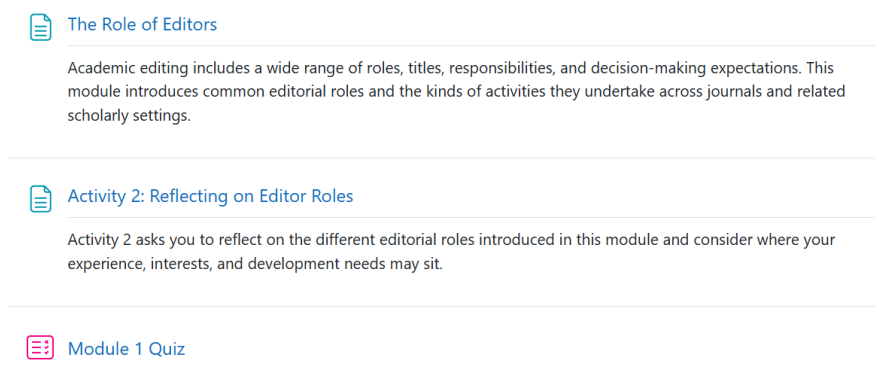
Issue 4: The logo

The logo displayed in the left upper corner of the platform does not match the specifications in the brand book. Difference can be seen below:

OAPA Academy - oapa.

Issue 5: Icon colours

The display icons in the platform are important in specifying the content type such as the file's icons. However, the ones shown below have several issues:



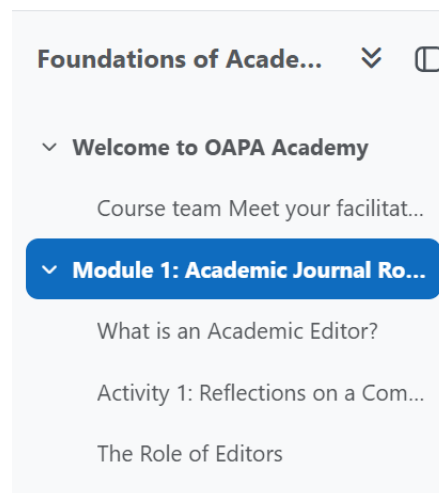
1. **Mismatch with the client brand book** that specifies that the OAPA's brand colours are black and white.

2. It goes against the **Aesthetic and minimalist** design heuristic.

Recommendation: change the colour of the icons to black.

Issue 6: Left-side panel navigation colour

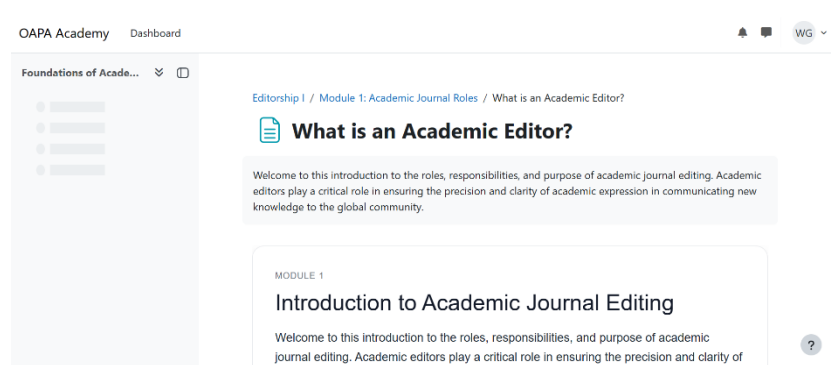
When navigating in the side panel, the tab that the user is on moves and highlights in blue where the user currently is shown below:



Recommendation: the colour should be changed to suit the design requirements from the brand book.

Issue 7: Left-side panel loading and loading time

When the user clicks on a module in the left-side panel it loads for 2.5 seconds. Although the program is loading the content, the panel should not disappear when back-end calls are taking place as shown in the image below:



The issues this causes in:

1. **Visibility and system status:** the user should not have the main navigation tool disappear for no reason for 2.5 seconds.

Recommendation: the left side panel should not move at all when the user clicks on a tab in the panel unless the page was refreshed.

Issue 8: Inclusion of tabs in main content area

Foundations of Academic Journal Editing

Course Participants Grades Activities Competencies

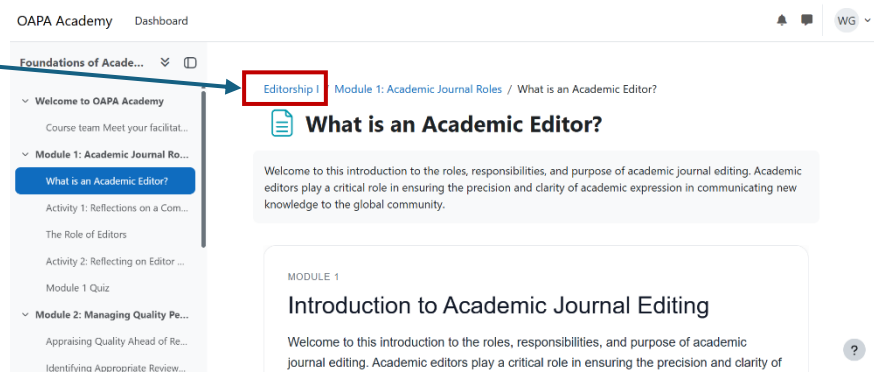
The inclusion of navigation tabs in the main content area such as Participants, Grades, Activities and Competencies. The main content area is for the display of the course content when the 'Course' tab is selected and when the left modules navigation tab is open. Participants, Grades and Competencies are technically not related to the course content.

Recommendation: the horizontal navigation tab should be moved to the top part of the page.

Issue 9: Horizontal tabs, navigation and error prevention

When the user clicks on the modules and start reading through the course content, if they need to check any of the tabs, such as Participants, their only option would be to click on the first link in the breadcrumb navigation as shown in the figure below:

Only way to get back to the navigation tabs



The option is called 'Editorship 1', which is unclear to the user what is it and if it's the way to go back in the navigation. This issue touched on the lack of:

1. **Visibility of System Status:** the user does not know where they are and how to get back to navigation.
2. **User control and freedom:** the user does not have the control and freedom they require when it comes to navigation.
3. **Recognition rather than recall:** the user has to remember and experiment with the feature, rather than recognising the option to go back.
4. **Flexibility and efficiency of use:** the feature is not flexible, and does not make it efficient for the user

Recommendation: keep the breadcrumb navigation but change the wording as well as the architecture of where it will be pointing to.

Issue 10: The left-module panel when the tab is not 'course'

The left module navigation panel still appears even after another unrelated tab is open.

Recommendation: only allow the left module tab to be open when the user is on the course tab.

Issue 11: Participants tab table design

The participants tab has a complicated table design. The table includes the participants' names and information:

OAPA Academy Dashboard

30 participants found

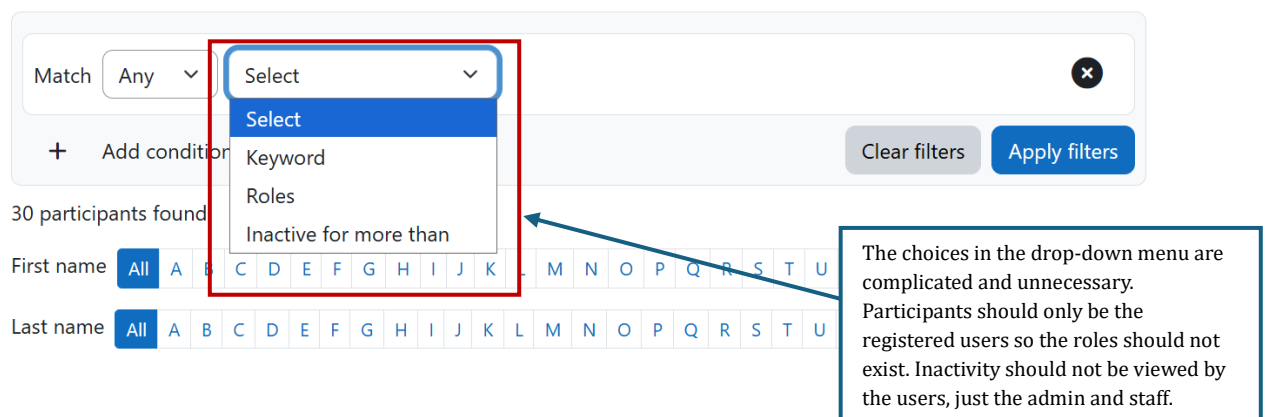
First name: All A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z

Last name: All A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z

1 2 »

	First name / Last name ↕	Roles	Groups	Last access to course
☐	MA Marii Abdeljaoued	Student	No groups	18 days 10 hours
☐	BB Becca Beights	Student	No groups	16 days 20 hours
☐	JF Jane Fernandez	Student	No groups	Never
☐	WG Walaa Ghanduri	Student	No groups	now
☐	WG Wendy Grosvenor	Student	No groups	8 days 14 hours
☐	AH Andrew Holliman	Student	No groups	67 days 10 hours

It shows data that seems to be invasive for another user to see such as last access to the course. The search strategy is complicated and redundant. More complicated and unnecessary wordings, choices and tabs:



This causes the lack of:

1. **Aesthetic and minimalist** design, the design is complicated and messy

Recommendation: the entire participants design should be redone, with all participants visible initially and with a search bar.

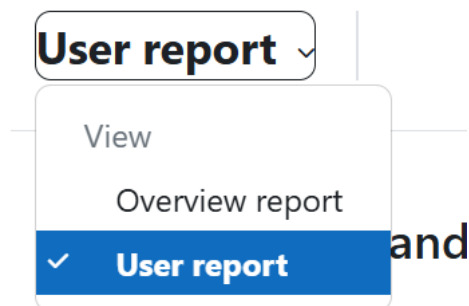
The table for the staff and admin should be different to the one visible to the user.

Issue 12: Grades tab default landing

The 'Grades' tab has a default landing which is in the 'user report' state:

Grade item	Calculated weight	Grade	Range	Percentage	Feedback	Contribution to course total
▼ Foundations of Academic Journal Editing						
ASSIGNMENT Associate Editor Portfolio	-	- ...	0-100	-		-
QUIZ Module 2 Quiz	-	- ...	0-10	-		-
QUIZ Module 1 Quiz	-	- ...	0-10	-		-
AGGREGATION Course total	-	-	0-220	-		-

The drop-down menu has two options:



Once clicked on the overview report, it takes us to all the courses the user has completed:

Overview report ▼

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Course name	Grade
Foundations of Academic Journal Editing	-

The user can again click on the course, and it takes them back to the user report. The issues here:

- The naming of the reports can confuse the user as both reports, whether course overview or module specific, are the user's.
- Redundancy in dropdowns such as the one below:

Grade item	Calculated weight	Grade	Range	Percentage	Feedback	Contribution to course total
Foundations of Academic Journal Editing						
ASSIGNMENT Associate Editor Portfolio	-	- ...	0-100	-		-
QUIZ Module 2 Quiz	-	- ...	0-10	-		-
QUIZ Module 1 Quiz	-	- ...	0-10	-		-
AGGREGATION Course total	-	-	0-220	-		-

User report ▾

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Grade item	Calculated weight	Grade	Range	Percentage	Feedback	Contribution to course total
Foundations of Academic Journal Editing						

Recommendation: to clean the grades tab; remove redundant and unnecessary features. As well as to improve the naming.

Issue 13: Lack of exit in Profile

Once the user is in their profile page, they cannot go back to the horizontal navigation tabs:

OAPA Academy Dashboard

Edit mode ☐ WG ▾

Reset page to default

WG Walaa Ghanduri Message

User details

[Edit profile](#)

Email address
 S4035762@student.rmit.edu.au (Visible to other course participants)

Timezone
 Europe/London

Reports

[Browser sessions](#)
[Grades overview](#)

Login activity

First access to site
 Tuesday, 25 August 2026, 4:33 AM (11 days)

Last access to site
 Saturday, 5 September 2026, 4:51 AM (1 hour)

Issue 14: High volume of notification configuration

	Web	Email 	Mobile 
Assignment			
Assignment notifications			
Assignment due soon notification			
Assignment overdue notification			
Assignments due in 7 days notification			
Feedback			
Feedback notifications			
Feedback reminder			
Forum			
Subscribed forum posts			
Subscribed forum digests			

Issue 15: The competencies drop-down not working

[Course](#)
[Participants](#)
[Grades](#)
[Activities](#)
[Competencies](#)

Course competencies

No competencies have been linked to this course.

× No filters applied

 Filter competencies by resource or activity ▼

Course team Meet your facilitators This course is ...
 What is an Academic Editor?
 Activity 1: Reflections on a Commentary
 The Role of Editors
 Activity 2: Reflecting on Editor Roles
 Module 1 Quiz
 Appraising Quality Ahead of Review
 Identifying Appropriate Reviewers

4. Prioritisation ranking

Priority	Issue No	Issue brief	Severity
1	1	Navigation in main content area	High
2	3	Navigation in modules	High
3	8	Inclusion of tabs in the main content area	High
4	7	Left-side panel loading and loading time	High
5	10	The left-module panel when the tab is not 'course'	High
6	11	Participants tab table design	High
7	13	Lack of exit in Profile	High
8	9	Horizontal tabs, navigation and error prevention	High
9	12	Grades tab default landing	Medium
10	14	High volume notification configuration	Medium
11	15	The competencies drop-down not working	Medium
12	2	Lack of progress indicators	Medium
13	4	The logo	Low
14	5	Icon colours	Low
15	6	Navigation colours (left-side panel)	Low